

TO: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent, Portland Public Schools
CC: Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations, Portland Public Schools
Date: November 25, 2025
FROM: The Office of School Improvement & Modernization and the Department of Research, Assessment, and Accountability

SUBJECT: Jefferson is Rising: An Analysis of Data from Community Engagement Activities

Executive Summary

To address enrollment challenges stemming from the 2011 Dual Assignment policy, Portland Public Schools (PPS) is transitioning Jefferson High School (JHS) back to a comprehensive neighborhood school. As the district explores potential new enrollment boundary scenarios, the Office of School Improvement & Modernization, in partnership with the Family and Community Engagement (FACE) team, conducted six listening sessions, offered a Slido poll, and collected feedback using an online feedback form in October and November of 2025. This memo synthesizes the findings from that community feedback and offers recommendations for next steps.

Of the 244 community members that completed the online feedback form, nearly half preferred *Enrollment Scenario C: Reimagine regional enrollment to balance access and opportunity across schools*. Survey respondents were also asked if they had any questions about the process or about Jefferson Rising. Their questions fell into three broad categories:

- **Questions about academic and extracurricular programming at Jefferson High School**, including how PPS will provide equitable access to Advanced Placement courses, electives, and sports before JHS reaches full enrollment
- **Questions about the timeline of this process**, including why the transition must take place before construction is complete in 2029
- **Questions about students' experiences attending a school while construction is ongoing**, including safety and noise concerns

Notes from table groups at each of the community listening sessions were also analyzed. Four dominant themes emerged from the listening sessions:

- **Disrupted trust:** Many participants expressed feeling that the decision had "already been made" and that community engagement was happening too late in the process
- **Clarity before commitment:** Families repeatedly requested a detailed, written plan guaranteeing equitable access to robust academic and extracurricular programming, even before JHS reaches full enrollment
- **Concern about timeline:** A primary concern was the plan to transition students while the school is under active construction. Many families expressed strong preferences to delay the boundary changes until the new building is complete in 2029, citing safety and environmental concerns
- **Consideration of gentrification, race, and school culture:** Participants engaged in thoughtful discussion about the project's impact on Jefferson High School as a historically Black space

We offer the following recommendations for future Jefferson Rising engagement:

- **Collect Additional Data:** Systematically collect data on participation numbers and provide voluntary opportunities for participants to share demographic information (e.g., school community, role, race/ethnicity, DLI program affiliation) to better understand stakeholder perspectives and ensure the most affected communities are heard
- **Ensure Equitable Access to Community Feedback Resources:** Make materials and feedback forms easily available in all five PPS languages (Spanish, Mandarin, Russian, Somali, and Vietnamese) and continue to offer multimodal (in-person, virtual) engagement options

Jefferson is Rising:
An Analysis of Data from Community Engagement Activities

Introduction

In 2011, Portland Public Schools began a Dual Assignment program at Jefferson High School. Intended to support Jefferson's Middle College program and give students assigned to Jefferson the option to attend a nearby comprehensive high school (Grant, McDaniel, or Roosevelt), this policy inadvertently led to fragmented enrollment across high schools.

In 2022, the PPS Board directed that a plan to increase enrollment at Jefferson be in place by 2027. Last spring, Superintendent Armstrong initiated the end of the Dual Assignment system in order to return Jefferson to a comprehensive high school model. In May 2025 voters approved full funding to modernize Jefferson High School. Construction begins this school year, with new, state-of-the art facilities opening in Fall 2029.

PPS staff have developed several scenarios that would convert HS Dual Assignment zones to neighborhood boundaries. Each plan would bring growth to Jefferson and lead to increased academic, elective and support opportunities for students. The scenarios differ in the estimated enrollment at other nearby high schools, the proportion of students who would move together from middle school to high school, among other factors.

To that end, the Office of School Improvement & Modernization with the support of the Family and Community Engagement Team (FACE) have been conducting community listening sessions and collecting feedback about the enrollment boundary scenarios and the engagement process itself. Listening sessions were held at Ockley Green Middle School (October 20), Harriet Tubman Middle School (October 23), Faubion PK-8 (October 27), Vernon K-8 (October 29), virtually (November 5) and at SEI (November 6). A feedback form was also made available on the PPS website.

This memo synthesizes the notes recorded during each listening session and analyzes the quantitative and qualitative data collected in the community feedback form. At the end, we then offer recommendations for the Jefferson Rising project going forward.

Due to timeline constraints, this memo analyses feedback from each of the in-person listening sessions and all survey responses. Notes from the virtual engagement session were not available at the time of writing.

Data and Analytic Approach

After community members participated in listening sessions and completed the feedback form, the Research, Assessment, and Accountability team received data in order to provide support with both quantitative and qualitative analysis.

The following data were collected during the community engagement events:

- Community Feedback Form Survey (244 respondents)
- Notes summarizing table talk events at five in-person listening sessions and one virtual session (401 participants)
- Slido poll questions asked in each of the listening sessions

Data were analyzed in the following ways:.

- ***Feedback form data*** were cleaned and descriptive statistics were calculated for quantitative questions. Qualitative responses were aggregated at the listening session level. Using an inductive approach, responses were individually coded to create a list of themes.
- ***Listening session data*** were aggregated and analyzed for themes using an inductive approach. Findings were aggregated at the listening session level to compare feedback associated with different school communities. Because this data comprises summaries of table discussion, it may not be representative of all voices at each table. However, it still provides critical insight into community-centered discussions about the Jefferson Rising initiative.

These findings, while important for making a community-informed decision, may not comprise a representative sample. Additionally, because participant demographics were not collected, we can draw limited conclusions about how representative attendees were of the affected stakeholders.

Findings

Feedback Survey

In total, 244 respondents had answered the Jefferson Is Rising: Community Feedback Form. This form was posted on the PPS website, and was available in English, Spanish, Somali, Simplified Chinese, Russian, and Vietnamese. It closed on November 14th. The majority of responders had the opportunity to attend one of the community listening sessions. See Table 1 for a breakdown of respondents by session.

Table 1: Feedback form respondents by listening session attended

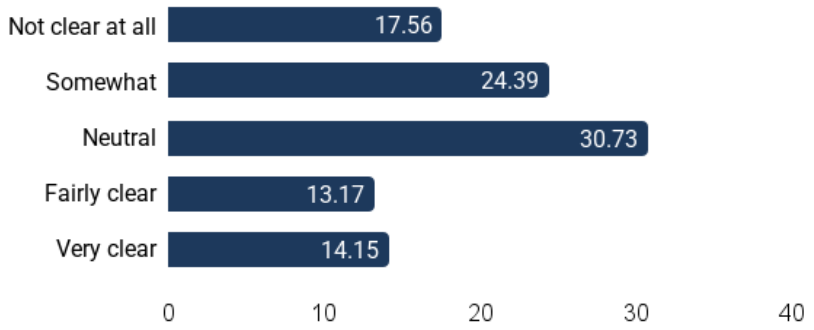
Session	Count	% of Respondents
Faubion PK-8	17	6.97
Harriet Tubman MS	91	37.3
I wasn't able to attend a session	58	23.77
Ockley Green MS	14	5.74
Other	11	4.51
SEI	4	1.64
Vernon K-8	19	7.79
Zoom	30	12.3

Here, we present quantitative and qualitative findings from the community feedback form.

Prior Knowledge and Experience at Listening Sessions

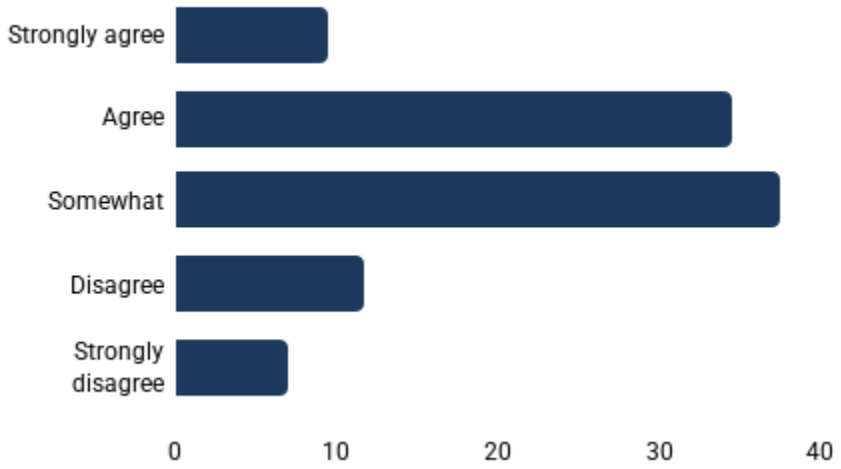
When asked how clear the shared information about Jefferson Rising was prior to this engagement session, 205 participants answered. Less than a quarter of participants reported feeling fairly or very clear about Jefferson Rising prior to the engagement session. See Chart 1 for a breakdown of participants' understanding of Jefferson Rising before attending a listening session.

Chart 1: How clear was the information you received about Jefferson Rising before the session? (in percent)



Taken together, participants reported not going into this listening session with much knowledge about Jefferson Rising. However, when asked whether material about Jefferson Rising was presented in the listening session in a way that was easy to understand, 81% of participants agreed (n=189). See Chart 2 for a breakdown of session presentation clarity.

Chart 2: Was the session content presented in a way that was easy to understand? (in percent)



When asked to rate their overall experience of attending the session, 187 participants responded. The majority of respondents reported feeling neutral to good about their experience. Community members who did not attend a session were also able to complete this form. Overall, they rated their experience lower than those who actually attended in person. See Chart 3 for participants' overall experience ratings and Chart 4 for their experience aggregated by session.

Chart 3: How would you rate your overall experience at this session? (in percent)

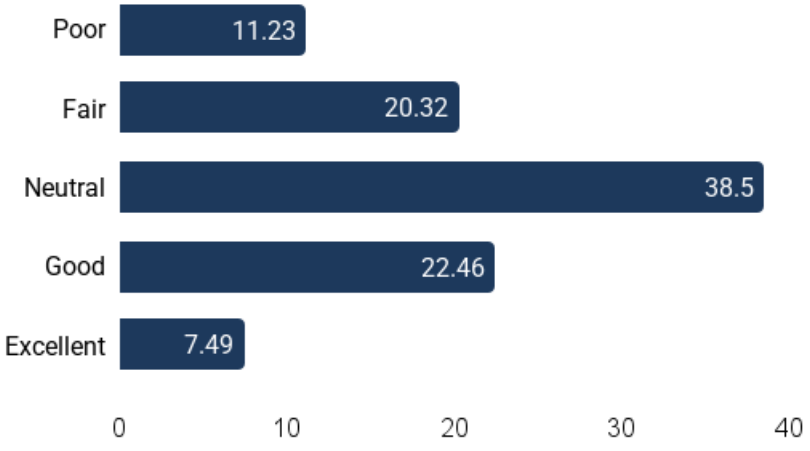
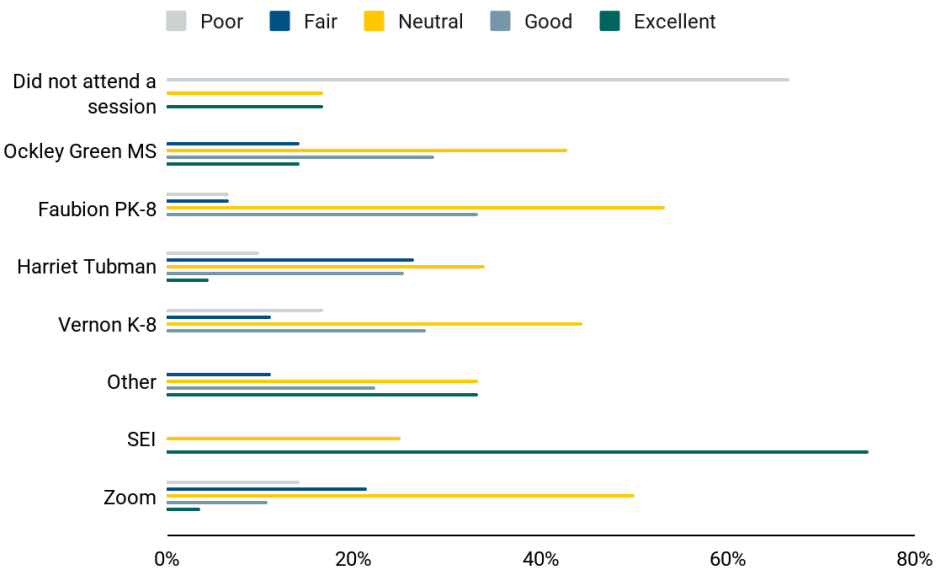
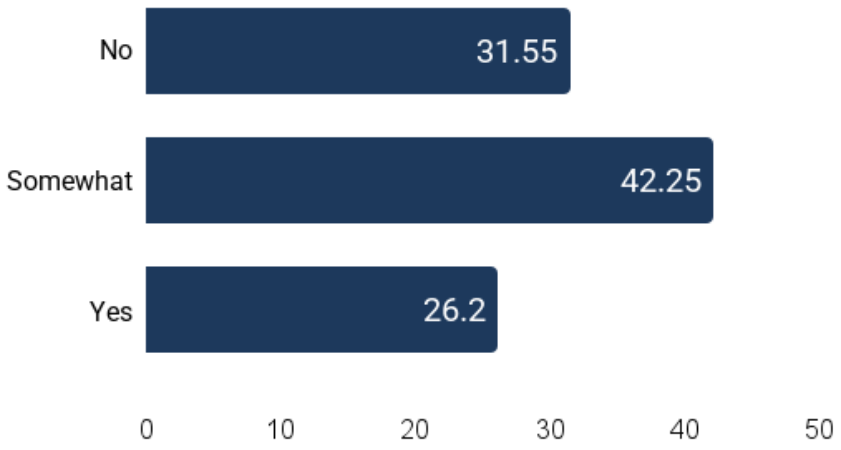


Chart 4: Rate your overall experience at the listening session, disaggregated by session



Finally, when asked whether their voice and perspective were taken into account, 187 participants responded. The majority of participants reported that they felt like their perspective was heard or somewhat heard. However, nearly one third of participants reported not feeling heard during the listening session. See Chart 5 for the percentage of participants who felt that their voices and perspectives were heard during their listening session.

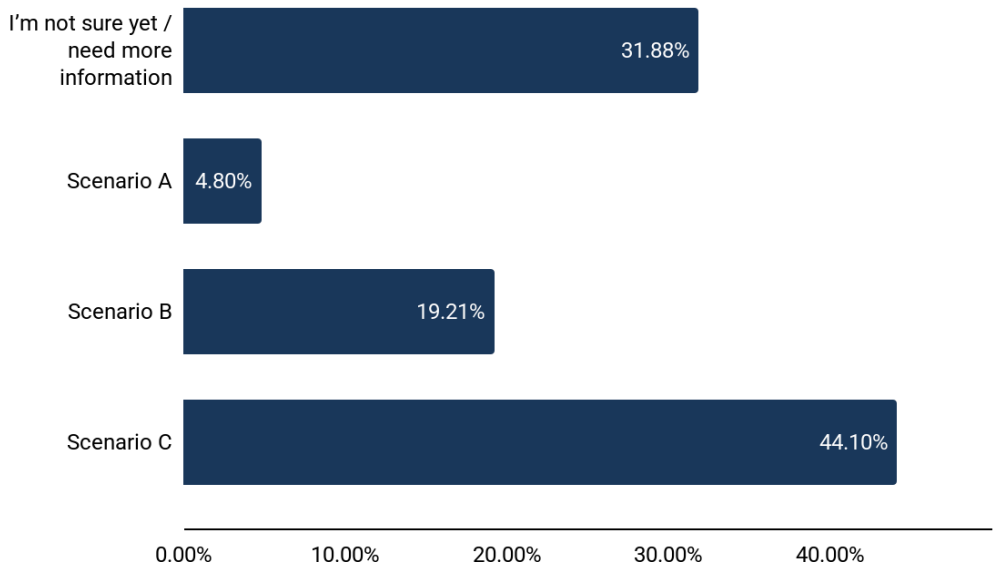
Chart 5: Do you feel your voice and perspective were heard during the session? (in percent)



Preferred Enrollment Scenarios for Jefferson High School

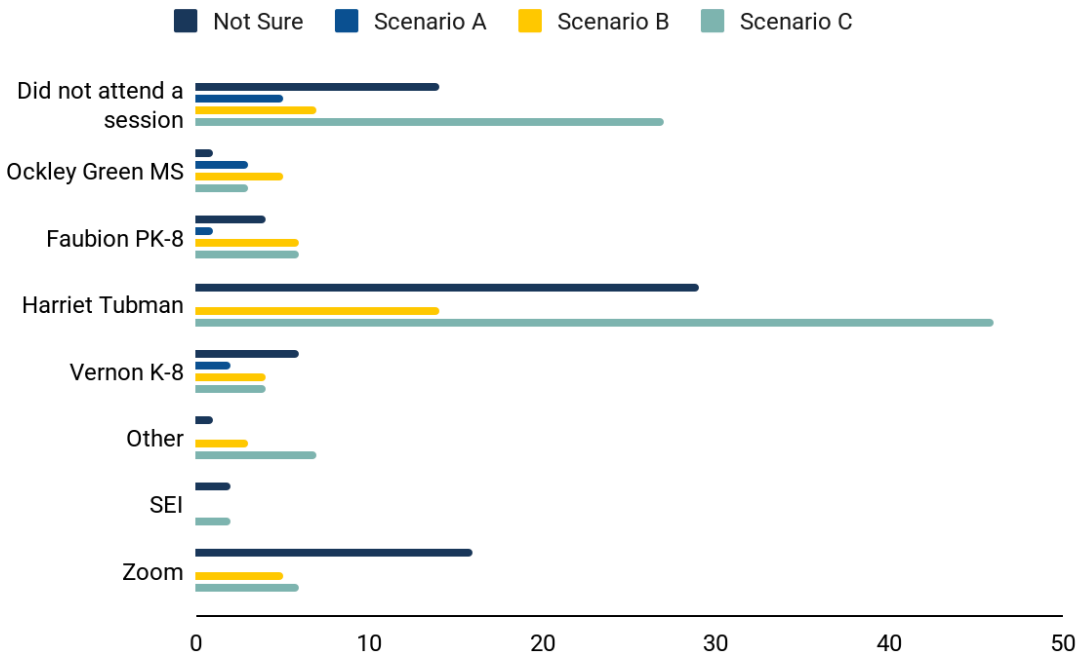
As part of the feedback form, participants were asked for their opinions regarding the future of Jefferson High School's enrollment patterns. When asked which scenario best supports becoming a strong neighborhood school, 229 participants provided an answer. Nearly half of respondents (44%) favored Scenario C (see Chart 6).

Chart 6: Which scenario do you feel best supports Jefferson becoming a strong neighborhood high school?



When broken down by which listening session respondents attended, it is evident that Scenario C was most popular among attendees at the Harriet Tubman MS session and those that did not attend a session. However, there was not a clearly preferred option that emerged from participant feedback at Ockley Green MS, Faubion PK-8, Vernon K-8, SEI, or virtually. Many community respondents remain unsure of what pathway they think best supports Jefferson becoming a strong neighborhood school. See Chart 7 for a count of preferred enrollment options disaggregated by listening session attendance.

Chart 7: Count of preferred scenario by listening session attendance



Emerging questions from community members

In the survey, 189 respondents answered the question, "What questions do you still have about Jefferson Rising or the changes ahead?" Community members' questions fell into three main buckets:

- Questions about the availability of academic and extracurricular programming at Jefferson High School, including how PPS will provide equitable access to Advanced Placement courses, electives, and sports before JHS reaches full enrollment
- Questions about the timeline of this process, including why the transition must take place before construction is complete in 2029
- Questions about students' experiences attending a school while construction is ongoing, including safety and noise concerns.

Taken together, families are primarily concerned with Jefferson's transitional years before it reaches full enrollment for a comprehensive high school.

Listening Sessions

Five in-person listening sessions took place at Vernon K-8, Faubion PK-8, Harriet Tubman MS, Ockley Green MS, and SEI. An additional listening session took place virtually, but notes from that session were not available and subsequently are not included in this

analysis. Because this analysis was conducted using aggregated notes and counts of participants were not provided, these findings are presented generally. To that end, quantifying thematic findings is not appropriate for this analysis.

In total, 401 community members participated in these listening sessions. See Table 2 for a breakdown of attendance and participation by session.

Table 2: Community feedback session participation

Session	Session Date	Number of Participants
Ockley Green MS	October 20, 2025	46
Tubman MS	October 23, 2025	117
Vernon K-8	October 27, 2025	44
Faubion PK-8	October 29, 2025	46
Virtual	November 5, 2025	99
Self Enhancement Inc. (SEI)	November 6, 2025	49
	TOTAL	401

Demographic information of participants was not recorded. In this analysis, we use the listening session attended as a proxy for middle school affiliation. However, information regarding participants' school affiliations was not recorded.

Data for each session were analyzed separately. However, the same four themes emerged from all discussions:

- Disrupted trust between the district and constituents
- Desire for clarity before commitment
- Opposition to the proposed timeline
- Gentrification and changing racial dynamics at Jefferson High School

Please note: few table sessions had notes reflecting specific discussions about the Boundary Enrollment Scenarios. Instead, discussions predominantly focused on community members' questions and concerns about the expansion of enrollment at Jefferson more broadly.

Theme 1: Disrupted trust between the district and constituents

Participants across sessions expressed some dissatisfaction with the engagement process and distrust between the district and community members. Many shared that they felt the decision had already been made, and wished they had been engaged earlier. Parents, particularly those from the Sabin and Irvington communities, felt they were not included in the conversation early enough in the process. One noted that "people don't even know this is happening."

Theme 2: Desire for clarity before commitment

Participants expressed significant concern regarding course and extracurricular offerings at Jefferson High School in the period leading up to full enrollment. Families reported wanting to see a written plan for academic and extracurricular access before sunsetting Dual Assignment. Sports and access to advanced academics like AP classes were critical concerns.

Class and extracurricular offerings may have an influence on enrollment. Some community members, especially those who would otherwise send their students to Grant High School, expressed concern that families will be more likely to send their children to private schools without the promise of diverse course and club offerings.

Theme 3: Opposition to the proposed timeline

Community members repeatedly expressed concern about the timeline for sunsetting Dual Assignment. They frequently cited one of two reasons for their concern: (1) sending students to a school under active construction and (2) insufficient time to authentically engage the community while making informed choices. Many expressed that they would be excited to send their students to Jefferson High School after the building modernization project has been completed. They shared concerns about safety and environmental distractions, like construction noise.

Theme 4: Gentrification and changing racial dynamics at Jefferson High School

Participants across community listening sessions engaged in thoughtful conversations about race and the implications of the shifting racial landscape of Jefferson High School, a historically Black space in Portland Public Schools. Because participants did not provide information regarding their identities or lived experiences, it is unknown whether participants were sharing perspectives from their lived experiences.

Many participants expressed concern regarding how increasing enrollment at Jefferson High School will significantly shift the school culture. Concerned about the impact of gentrification on the school community, one table group wondered about how Black families in the Jefferson school community will feel about the changing culture and

demographics. In another session, one parent of color expressed concern that their child's presence will become tokenized rather than central to the identity of Jefferson High School. Taken together, conversations like these provide insight into the concerns community members have about the changing culture at Jefferson High School.

Relatedly, participants raised a concern that the needs of the Latine community were not being taken into consideration, especially at Roosevelt High School. They expressed concern that this enrollment shift would have a destabilizing effect on this and other communities of color across Portland Public Schools.

Slido Data

While participating in the listening session, attendees were given the opportunity to respond to a series of Slido questions ranking their priorities for the future of Jefferson Rising. Below, data are reported in aggregate from the Ockley Green, Harriet Tubman, Faubion, and Vernon listening sessions. At this time, Slido data are not available from the virtual session or the SEI session. Participants were asked to rank how important a variety of factors are in the decision making process.

Overall, the majority of participants ranked all factors as either Important or Very Important. However, participants were in agreement that offering a wide range of academic programs, college and career pathways, and extracurricular opportunities and course progressions was very important. Geographical proximity was also a widely supported factor. Few other factors were as unanimously valued.

Taken together, data from the Slido survey results suggests that providing robust academic and extracurricular offerings is most important, but all of the other listed factors should also be seriously considered when planning enrollment changes. See Charts 8-13 below for charts representing each of the Slido questions.

Chart 8: Slido results for the question: "How important is it that any new plan centers the experiences and success of Black/African American students and other historically marginalized communities?" (n = 150)

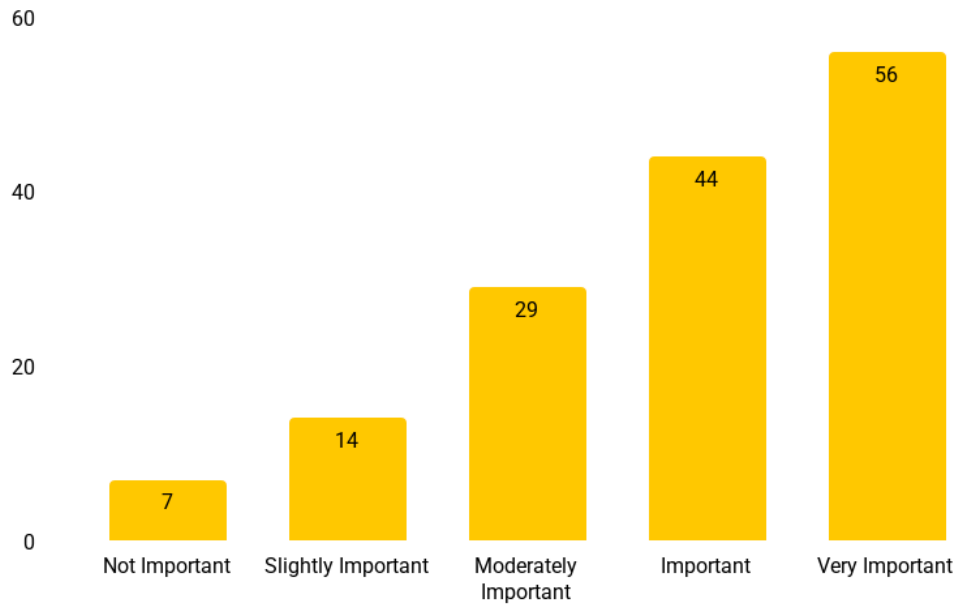


Chart 9: Slido results for the question, "How important is it that students can attend a high school geographically close to their home and community?" (n = 152)

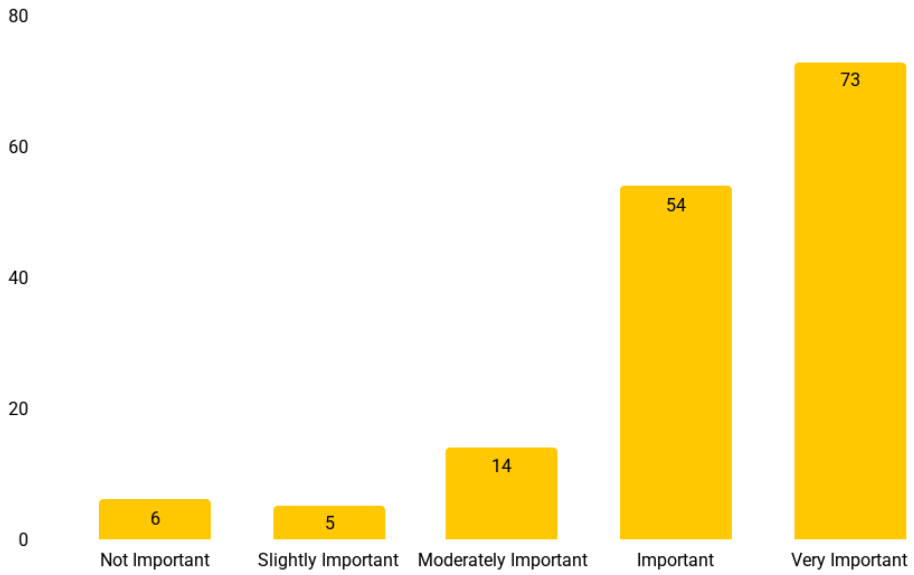


Chart 10: Slido results for the question, "How important is it that Jefferson offers a wide range of academic programs, college and career pathways, and extracurricular opportunities and course progressions that allow students to deeply explore some areas of study?" (n = 151)

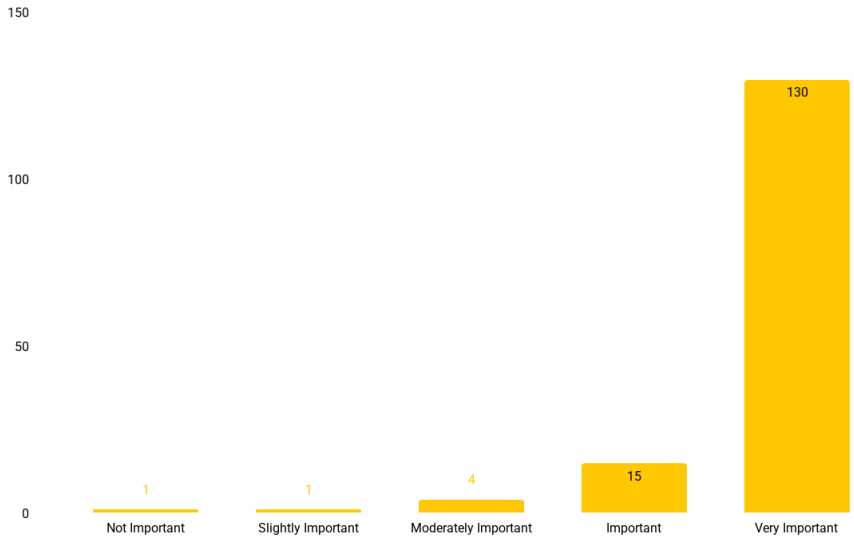


Chart 11: Slido results for the question, "How important is it that students experience minimal disruption to their school placement or learning environment during the transition?" (n = 150)

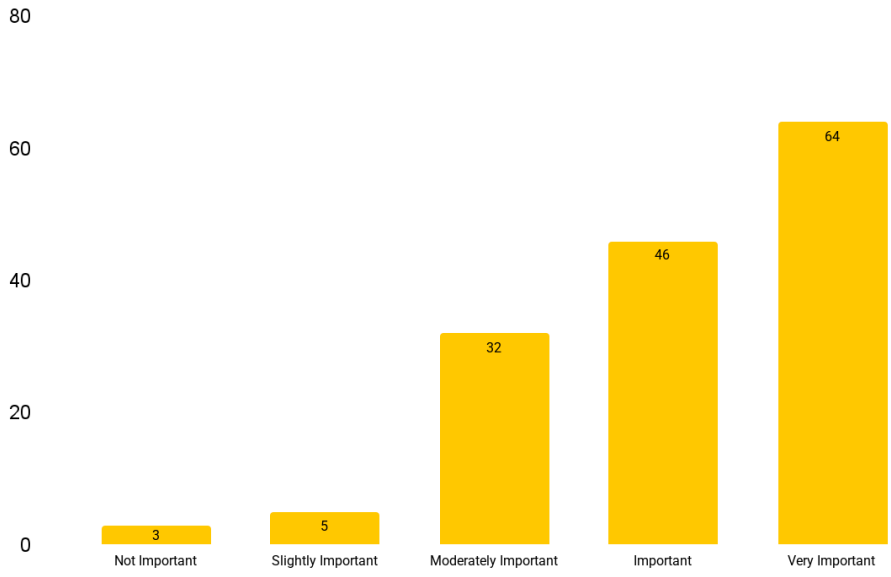


Chart 12: Slido results for the question, "How important is it that Jefferson continues to serve as a cultural and community hub for North and Northeast Portland families?" (n = 151)

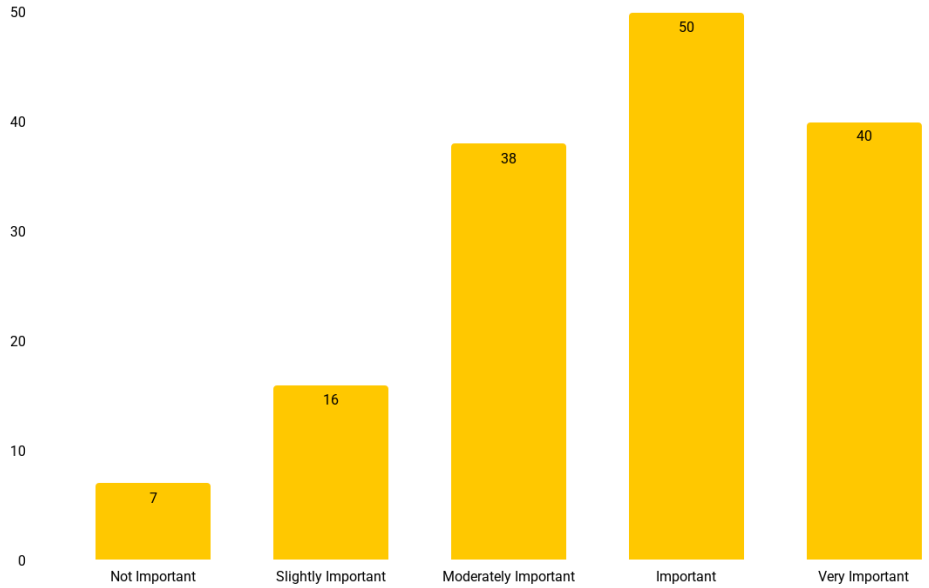
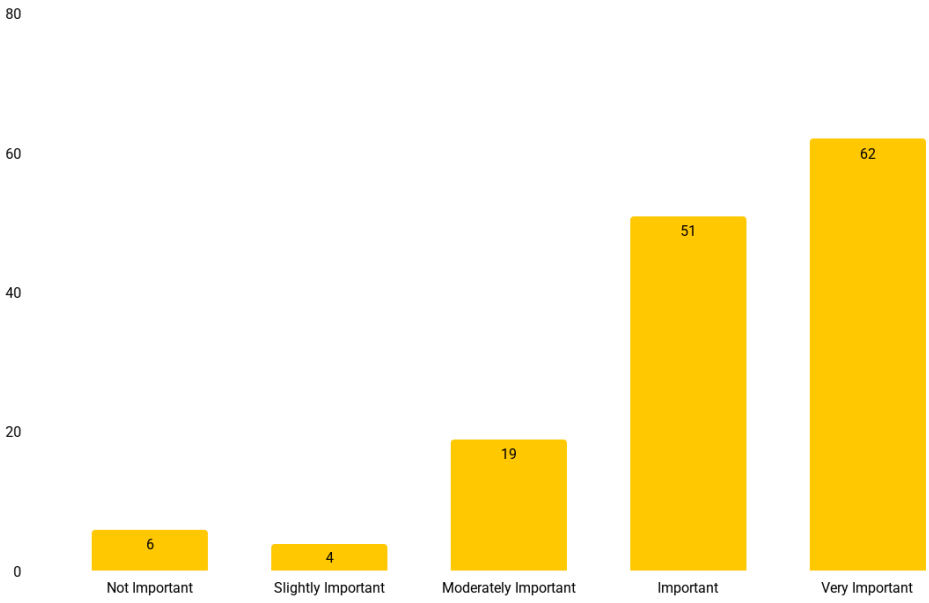


Chart 13: Slido results for the question, "How important is it that decisions made now ensure long-term sustainability and growth for future generations of Jefferson students?" (n = 142)



Recommendations and Next Steps

Here, we present recommendations based on the feedback from approximately 400 stakeholders who attended listening sessions and 244 feedback form responses:

- When creating a plan for the Jefferson Rising enrollment redesign, include detailed plans with opportunities for community input and feedback around:
    - (1) Ensuring access to academic courses and extracurricular activities and
    - (2) Risk and noise mitigation while students attend a school that is under construction
- Continue to engage students and community members in every stage of the policy design and implementation process. Collect more demographic information from stakeholders to ensure that diverse voices are heard, especially Black students and families.

For continued community engagement efforts regarding specific plans for Jefferson High School, we offer the following suggestions:

- Continue to offer multimodal, multilingual options for community members to learn and share their feedback
- Ensure straightforward, equitable access to all materials, including surveys and handouts, in all five PPS languages (English, Spanish, Mandarin, Russian, Somali, and Vietnamese)
- Create opportunities to collect demographic data about participants, including school community, community role, participant race/ethnicity, and whether families participate in a Dual Language Immersion (DLI) program. This could be accomplished using sign in sheets, surveys, or exit tickets
- Review data collection instruments to ensure data are actionable; follow survey design best practices by asking one question at a time
- During listening sessions, provide sufficient time for community discussions
- Direct notetakers to capture more observable data rather than summarizing as they go (e.g., quotes, how many people were at the table, topics discussed)

By systematically collecting data during culturally responsive community engagement efforts, we will be well-positioned to deeply engage with diverse perspectives and community voice.